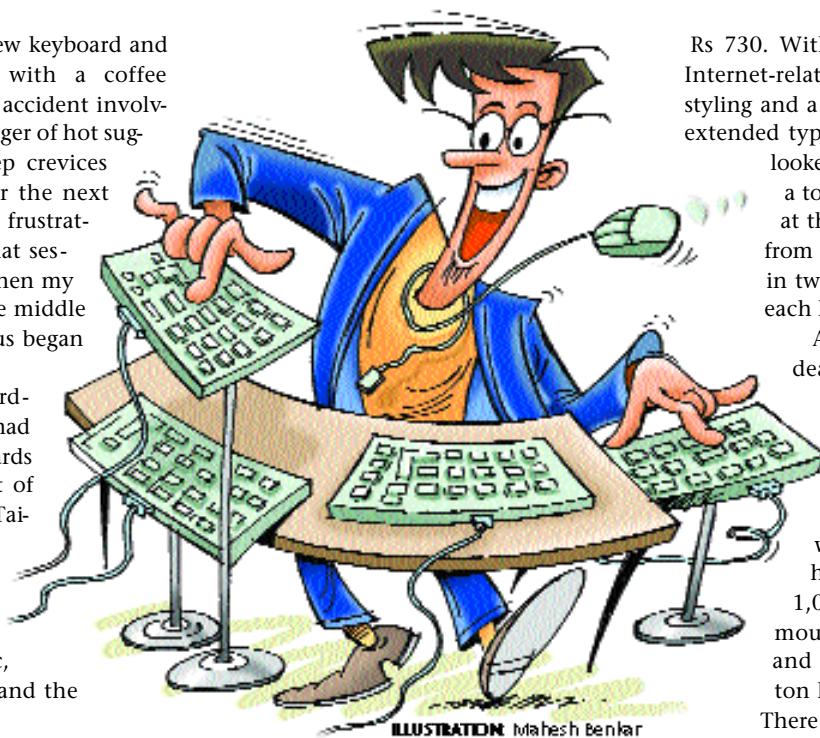


My quest for a new keyboard and mouse began with a coffee mishap, a fatal accident involving the unscheduled merger of hot sugary liquids and the deep crevices inside my keyboard. For the next two days I had the most frustrating and embarrassing chat sessions with my friends. Then my mouse died on me in the middle of a gaming session. Thus began Mission: Input Devices.

Even the smallest hardware store in my suburb had a variety of cheap keyboards and mice. There's a glut of brandless Chinese and Taiwanese mice available for as low as Rs 120. I personally hate these cheap Chinese makes. They aren't ergonomic, have no scroll features, and the buttons feel tacky.

The basic Samsung and Acer keyboards were rated '*sasta and tikau*' by a dealer in Andheri, Mumbai, and were among the most affordable keyboards I came across. While these keyboards did not have any extra features such as additional shortcut keys, at Rs 500 and 300 respectively, I didn't expect anything more. I liked the way the keys felt soft and responsive and they didn't make too much noise—that's all I wanted from a keyboard.

A dealer in Borivili, Mumbai, had a stack of iBall mice in different colours. I liked the iBall mouse—it's a good buy for 400 bucks and it can scroll vertically and horizontally with acceptable precision. The PS/2 Logitech



Mission: Input Devices

Agent 001 scours the streets in search for a keyboard and mouse

scroll mouse, selling at Rs 650, was rated a hot item according to him. It's versatile, durable, accurate and ergonomic. I highly recommend it for its price.

If you want a multimedia keyboard with shortcuts to the Internet and multimedia applications, try the Maple Internet Media keyboard—it features a good layout and includes 15 programmable keys along with eight exclusive function keys—all for a cheap Rs 775. I also took a liking to Logitech's Deluxe Access 104 keyboard for

Rs 730. With quick access buttons for Internet-related tasks, an ergonomic styling and a palm rest that helps during extended typing sessions, this keyboard looked like a good buy. If you are a touch typist who doesn't look at the keyboard, try the EKB804 from Maple—the keys are divided in two halves for easier access by each hand.

A little later I came across a dealer who only stocked A4-tech mice—double scroll mice, five-button mice, trackball mice, infrared trackball mice with scroll buttons, radio frequency wireless trackball mice—he had them all at under Rs 1,000. The WWT 5E trackball mouse with two scroll wheels and a programmable third button looked tempting at Rs 800. There were prettier versions of the same mice too, with a translucent iMac-like design for Rs 100 extra.

While optical mice are more expensive than conventional mice, they are durable and long-lasting since they have no moving parts and can be used on any surface. Their prices have fallen over the last few years—the Logitech White Optical was only Rs 1,200, while the WOP35 from Maple was available for Rs 1,100. And if you go in for a keyboard and optical mouse combo, you could get them both for less than Rs 2,000—a steal if you ask me.

The Cordless Freedom Optical keyboard and mouse combo from Logitech is the ultimate combination. There are no cords, the keyboard has Internet and multimedia keys that allow you to connect to the Net and control MP3s, DVDs and CDs, and the optical mouse is ergonomically designed (although it's more suited to right-handers). However, at Rs 8,000, this combination is certainly not for everyone. I drooled over the trackball mice from Logitech—it's the lazy man's pointing device that needs only the twiddling of the fingers with no wrist work and is very comfortable to use once you get used to it. But it's expensive at Rs 5,000.

After doing the rounds of the marketplace, I looked in my wallet, and finally settled for the Samsung keyboard and the iBall mouse for Rs 800—after a little bargaining, of course. ■



■ Do not buy the mouse if the mouse ball is hollow and light; it translates into poor movement.

■ Consider yourself to be the Joe Satriani of touch typing? If you never look at the keyboard while you type, you qualify. Buy yourself a natural keyboard, where the keys are divided from the centre at an ergonomic angle to make touch typing easier.

■ Optical mice are more expensive than PS/2 mice, but they are very durable since they have no moving parts. Plus they are more accurate.

■ Buy a keyboard with wrist support—it will help you during extended typing sessions.

■ Suffer from calloused wrists? Buy a trackball mouse, you will never have to move your hands again—just your fingers!

■ Infrared or radio frequency cordless mice are ideal if you yearn for an uncluttered desktop.

■ PS/2 mice are more responsive than serial mice as you can tweak them to operate at a higher refresh rate and are definitely recommended for gaming.